I tried to ignore the Loews and concentrate on our walking tours of art deco architecture. This was difficult, and almost impossible. Things got even more difficult when, on a return to our hotel, I found an urgent message from Ms. Garrett in our pigeonhole. It said something about a "margin call." Fortunately, my wife hadn't seen it.

I crumpled up the message as quickly as possible and later returned alone to the hotel lobby to phone Ms. Garrett from a pay station. "You're in trouble now," she said. "You've got to put in more money to cover your short position." Besides the Loews sinking fast, my Angstrom shares were now considered unworthy collateral by her accounting department. She said she'd cover for me and stall as long as possible, which I appreciated. She left me the strong impression that I'd better send cash right away.

Here I have another embarrassing confession: I wired $4,000 out of the general household funds and never told my wife. In fact, when she reads this I hope I'm not in the room. I'd like to remind her that I'll make it up to her somehow, that I put back $2,000 of it from the closing of the Lind-Waldock account, and that she still hasn't reached the end of the book.

Even after I put up the extra $4,000, I got another urgent message about another margin call. It was partly to avoid such horrible surprises that I suggested to my wife we change hotels because our room was too small. Since I'd been careful not to leave a forwarding address or phone number at the old hotel, I was temporarily liberated from more pink slips from Ms. Garrett's office. For two days, I ignored my troubles and concentrated on the Wrigley Building and the metalwork around the doors at the Carson Pirie Scott department store. I tried to pretend that Loews, the stock market, Prudential-Bache, and Ms. Garrett had never existed.

Finally, I could hold out no longer. After a particularly disastrous session with the Dow Jones average down 45 points, I called Ms. Garrett from another phone booth and put myself at her mercy. "I can't send more money," I said. "Then we'll have to buy back the puts," she insisted. "We have no other choice." I don't think I ever felt worse, but I told her to do what had to be done. Buying back the 10 Loews September $70 puts cost me $8,429.10. At least I wouldn't get any more margin calls.